

Inventor Takes On Einstein

BY ROBERT GILLETTE
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Hope springs eternal, but never so buoyantly as in the heart of an inventor convinced he has defeated the laws of physics and brought Einstein's theory of relativity crashing down like a house of cards.

So it was Thursday in the heart of industrial Glendale, down behind the potholed parking lot of the Tru-Cut, Inc., lawnmower shop, in a dark rented shed bear-



Dr. Keith Kenyon

ing the handpainted orange sign, "Solar World, mfrs. of wind turbines and the Kenyon Alternator."

It is a modest enterprise with no manufacturing equipment in evidence and an apparently unlisted telephone number.

In a swirl of television lights and out-thrust microphones, a Van Nuys physician, Dr. Keith Kenyon, unveiled his invention: an electrical generator which, he said, produces more energy than it uses and promises "to relieve the world's energy shortage."

The Kenyon Alternator proves, on inspection, to be a crudely built device resembling a bicycle wheel with magnets on the rim. When spun by a 5-horsepower electric motor it whirs and clanks and shudders and produces enough electricity to illuminate a panel of 100-watt bulbs.

But the claim that it produces more energy than it uses runs counter to numerous laws of physics, and has earned the device a polite brushoff from the U.S. Department of Energy, which hears about scores of such ideas each year.

What sets this one apart from most is the enthusiastic support it receives from former Los Angeles Mayor Sam Yorty. In recent weeks Yorty has repeatedly urged reporters to write about the device, which is the pet project of his friend and longtime physician, Kenyon.

"I really think Dr. Kenyon has something," Yorty said in a letter to The Times on March 14. At the news conference Thursday, he hovered behind a semicircle of television cameras and reporters in the gloom of the rented shed, plumping for Kenyon and his invention: "They've really got something haven't they? I think it's very interesting, don't you?" Yorty said, gesturing toward the spinning device, which radiated copper wires like an old electric hair curler.

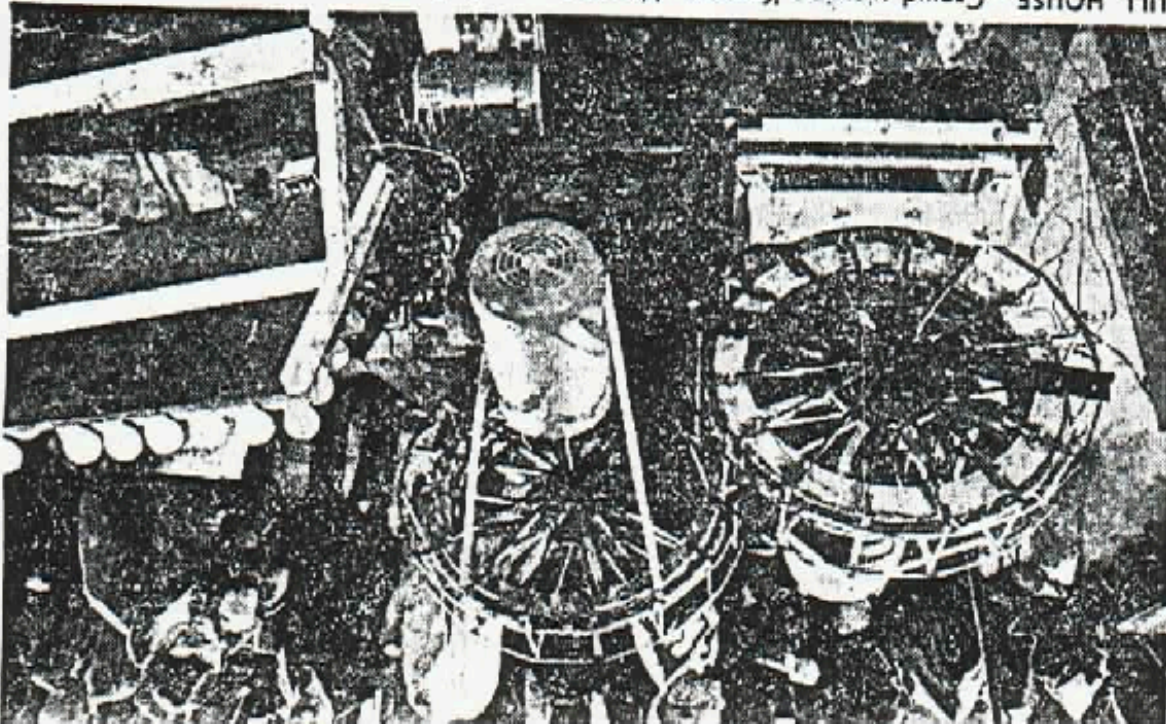
Yorty said he had no financial interest in the device.

But his presence—and claims by the device's various backers that they have received expressions of interest from such sources as USC, Caltech's Jet Propulsion Laboratory and former astronaut Gordon Cooper—help generate what is probably the only entry on earth genuinely capable of putting out more than goes into it, the quintessential media event.

Astronaut Cooper could not be reached for comment. But Dr. Peter Campbell, a professor of electrical engineering at USC who was one of 12 persons advertised in a news release to have "agreed" . . . to evaluate the evidence, said that the claims were outrageous. He also said he had no association with the project and had

Times photos by Bill Warte

FULL HOUSE—Crowd viewing Kenyon Alternator as it illuminates a panel of lightbulbs.



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